Neither the Oirat nor the Ming were exactly sure where China began and the lands of the nomadic steppe dwellers ended, which made the border war complicated. And the Hongwu Emperor, cautious by nature, was wary of launching unnecessary campaigns. But he was also aware (with an almost pathological intensity) that a line between *China* and *barbarian* existed, even if he didn't know exactly where it was. "The Yuan was created by northern barbarians entering and residing in China," he wrote, early in his reign. "How could the barbarians rule the Chinese? I fear that the heartland has long been stained with the stink of mutton. . . . Therefore I have led forth armies to make a clean sweep. My aim is to chase out the Mongol slaves . . . to cleanse China of shame." By the end of his reign, in 1398, he had built a string of fortresses out into the steppe country, bases from which to raid deep into Northern Yuan and Oirat lands. [1]

He had many sons, but the oldest, his crown prince, had died before him; and so he had chosen the crown prince's oldest son, Jianwen, to succeed him. When the grandson was crowned in Nanjing, the Hongwu Emperor's fourth son Zhu Di, military governor of the old Mongol city of Dadu, challenged him. More than three years of civil war followed. In 1402, Zhu Di and his army marched into Nanjing and burned down young Jianwen's imperial palace. The boy himself was said to have died in the fire, but rumors of his reappearance would spread constantly through the rest of his uncle's reign. [2]

Zhu Di named himself the Yongle Emperor and ordered that the brief rule of his nephew be wiped from the official Ming record books. Like his autocratic father, he crushed all possible opposition with an immediate purge: tens of thousands of Jianwen's supporters (or suspected supporters) were murdered. When the boy's chief counselor, Fang Xia, refused to recognize the new Yongle Emperor as legitimate, he was sentenced to death by public dismemberment: *zhe*, a version of drawing and quartering that could take as long as three days.[3]

The Hongwu Emperor had fought on land; the Yongle Emperor set his sights on the sea.

Between 1405 and 1422, he ordered six massive naval expeditions launched from the coast of China, headed out to the western ports: first to India and then to the shores of south Asia, to Sri Lanka, to the islands of the Maldives, to Mecca, and finally to the eastern edge of the African continent. The commander in chief of these expeditions was the Grand Eunuch Cheng Ho, the superintendent of all royal eunuchs; the voyages were recorded by the geographer Ma-Huan, who accompanied Cheng Ho from the second journey on.

Like his Muslim counterparts, Ma-Huan made note of the customs, the